

ROYA

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THE PAINLESS REEL

*Some memories
should stay
on the cutting
room floor.*



Chew Z

—◆— A ROYA PUBLICATION —◆—

THE PAINLESS REEL

A Confession in Five Reels

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THE PAINLESS REEL

A Roya Publication

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Synopsis

In the back room of an unmarked parlor on Vine, a lonely man discovers a drug called Halo — sold to people who no longer want to be themselves for an hour.

Halo doesn't show you lights, or gods, or your own childhood. It gives you someone else's worst night, lived from inside a man who felt none of the things a person is supposed to feel while doing it — and it feels, to the men and women paying for the privilege, like the first true peace of their lives. They come back shaking. They come back with marks they can't explain. They come back for more.

He tells himself he's only visiting, only curious, only once — and then a second time, and a third, and a fourth, building a gentler story about who he is with every visit, until a fifth, unlabeled reel shows him something no story can survive.

This is a noir about the second self we manufacture to outlive the first one, the appetite for a peace that was never ours to feel, and the particular horror of recognizing your own hands in the one memory you were never supposed to see.

A Note from the Author

This book began with a simple, uncomfortable question: what would you trade to stop feeling, even for an hour, the exact thing that makes you afraid to be yourself?

Halo isn't built as an escape. It's built as an exchange. Every reel gives you an hour inside somebody else's nervous system — a man who has never once, in thirty years of documented use, been recorded flinching at what his own hands were doing. You don't get his violence. You get the thing underneath it that customers actually pay for: the specific, catastrophic relief of feeling nothing at all where dread is supposed to live. You come back shaking. You come back marked. You come back for more, because the drug was never selling a vision. It was selling permission.

At the center of the book is a man who tells himself, every single time, that he's only visiting — a witness, not a participant, curious about somebody else's darkness rather than a resident of his own. Five reels in, that story runs out of road. What's waiting for him in the fifth reel isn't a stranger's memory. It's the one memory he's spent the entire book unconsciously building his personality around not having.

I wanted to write about the particular kind of forgetting that isn't really forgetting at all — the gentler story we construct, visit after visit, excuse after excuse, to make an unbearable fact survivable by relocating it onto somebody else. Chuck Palahniuk has talked about fiction that goes all the way into the graphic, unbearable places becoming a kind of permission slip for people carrying something they've never had anywhere honest to set down. That's what I wanted this book to be for the reader, the same way Halo is, in the story, for its customers — except I'd like to think this permission slip doesn't come with a bill attached.

You won't forget what he did by the end of this book. What you'll have a harder time doing is remembering how to want anything as cleanly as his customers wanted that one hour of not being themselves.

—Chew Z

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REEL ONE: WHAT I WENT LOOKING FOR

Nobody hired me to go looking for Halo. I want that on the record before anything else, because everything that follows only makes sense if you understand nobody sent me and nobody was paying me by the hour to be there. I went the way people go looking for anything they already half suspect might ruin them — quietly, on my own time, telling myself it was curiosity and nothing closer to hunger.

I'd heard the word the way you hear about a fire three blocks over — close enough to smell it, far enough to keep pretending it's somebody else's insurance problem — until it became, without my noticing exactly when, the only thing I thought about on the drive home. It had been a bad year before that, the kind that doesn't have a single clean story attached to it, just a slow accumulation of nights I lay awake doing math on all the ways I'd failed to be the kind of man who sleeps easily. I knew Halo was a drug. I knew it didn't get sold on corners, because corners are for people who still want to be found. I knew the ones who came out the other side of it stopped meeting your eyes head-on, like something in the angle of a direct look had started to cost them more than it used to.

What I didn't know, that first night, was that I was about to spend six weeks becoming a regular at a place built to sell people the one hour of their lives when they finally stopped being afraid of themselves — and that six weeks was going to turn out to be a great deal more dangerous than curiosity usually is.

A man ahead of me in the stairwell that first night, older, further along than I understood at the time, told me, real quiet, like the walls themselves had opinions: you go looking for Halo enough times, you stop finding out about the drug and start finding out about yourself. I wrote it down later, in my head, the way I write down everything that sounds like wisdom and turns out to be a confession nobody's ready to make yet, including, as it turned out, me.

REEL TWO: THE PARLOR ON VINE

The parlor on Vine didn't have a sign. It had a door that opened onto a stairwell that smelled like an ashtray had given up trying, and a woman at the bottom of it who introduced herself as Ruth and never once, in six weeks, gave me a last name to write down.

Ruth ran the place the way a good madam runs a house — not with menace, with hospitality, which is worse, because hospitality is what makes you comfortable enough to stay. She had a face built for trust, the kind that makes strangers hand over their coats and their car keys and, eventually, their whole evening, and she looked me over for exactly as long as it took to decide how much of the truth she was going to charge me for.

She told me Halo wasn't a hallucinogen, not the way the papers liked to write it up. She said the papers always wanted a molecule to blame, something with a structure you could put in a courtroom exhibit, and that made for a tidier story than the truth, which was that Halo didn't show anybody a vision. It gave them an hour inside somebody else's nervous system — a very specific somebody, a man customers only ever called the Painless Man, because in thirty years of documented work nobody had ever recorded so much as a flinch out of him. Not fear. Not hesitation. Not, and Ruth said this part very carefully, the thing normal people carry afterward that keeps them from doing it again.

I asked her again about it, straight, and she didn't flinch either, which I noted the way you note a family resemblance you're not ready to name yet. She said people didn't come to Vine for a trip. They came because they'd spent their entire lives afraid — of failing, of being seen, of the exact shape of their own anger — and for one hour, wearing someone else's calm the way you'd wear a coat that fit a bigger man, they got to feel what it was like to do the unthinkable thing and feel nothing but clean, complete relief on the other side of it.

I asked her what the unthinkable thing usually was.

She said that depended on the reel. She said it the way a sommelier discusses a vintage, and something about that particular calm in her voice made the hair stand up on my arms in a way six weeks of worse rooms never quite managed again.

I asked to see a customer come down from one.

She led me to a curtained booth where a man in a good suit sat very still with his hands open on his knees, palms up, the exact loose posture of somebody who has just set down something heavy he'd been carrying a long time. His eyes were open.

He wasn't blinking at any rate a person should be able to sustain. And around his throat, faint, like the ghost of a hand that had never actually been there, was a ring of bruising the color of a healing plum, in a shape too deliberate to be anything but a print.

REEL THREE: THE CUSTOMER

I told myself I was only going once, to see what the fuss was, and that's true the way most of the things I told myself that year were true — technically, and only if you didn't look at it too long.

Ruth didn't ask many questions about why a man my age wanted his first reel. She only asked whether I wanted an old one, safe, well-worn by a hundred customers before me, or something closer to new. I said old. I wasn't ready yet for anything the room still remembered clearly, though I couldn't have told you, at the time, what I meant by that, or why the word remembered was the one that came to mind for a piece of tape.

What I can tell you about the hour itself, I've told to exactly one other person, and I'm only telling you now because I no longer have a reason to protect the man I used to be from what he did to himself that night on a leather chair in a curtained booth on Vine.

It wasn't a hallucination. Ruth was right about that. It was a room, complete, down to the temperature of the air and the specific give of a floorboard under a shoe that wasn't mine, and there was a person in front of me who was frightened in a way I recognized instantly and hated myself for recognizing, because some old, ugly, curious part of every person, the part that slows down for wrecks on the highway, knows exactly what that particular fear looks like the first time it sees it up close. I want to tell you I felt what she felt. I didn't. That was the whole design of the thing, the whole cruelty of it, dressed up as a gift: I felt what he felt, watching her, which was nothing at all standing where fear should have been — a vast, cool, complete absence, spreading out in every direction like a held breath finally let go, and under that absence, worse than the absence, something that can only honestly be called joy.

I came up out of that chair the way a man comes up from drowning, except drowning is supposed to be the part you're grateful to survive, and some ungovernable, unforgivable back room of myself was already, already, missing the water.

My hands were shaking for three days. On the second day I noticed a faint discoloration starting at the pad of my thumb, the color of a healing bruise, in a shape that took me an embarrassingly long time to admit resembled the exact place a man's thumb sits when his hand is doing the one thing hands are never supposed to do to somebody who's begging them to stop.

I went back to Vine four more times before I understood what I was actually doing there. I want you to sit with that number for a second the way I've had to. Four. Not once, to steel myself against it. Four.

REEL FOUR: WHAT THE REELS ARE MADE OF

By my third month as a regular, I'd stopped being the kind of customer Ruth had to work to put at ease. I was the kind she talked to, a little, between reels, the way people talk to bartenders they've decided are safe enough to stop performing for.

She told me, one slow evening when the parlor was empty enough to hear the pipes, that the Painless Man wasn't thirty years dead the way the regulars liked to believe. She said the legend was good for business, a story with a tidy villain safely buried in the past, but the newest reels — the ones she only brought out for customers she trusted, the ones that still had a wet, unfinished quality the old customers swore they could feel, a rawness the worn reels had lost — those weren't thirty years old. Those were weeks.

I asked her what that meant, in words, because I needed to hear myself fail to say it before I'd let myself believe it.

She said it meant somebody was still working.

I want to be honest about what I did with that sentence, because honesty is the only currency I have left worth spending on you. I didn't ask any more questions than that, not that night. I told myself it wasn't my business, and that was a lie I could still, barely, afford. It was some weeks later, close enough to trusting her by then that the question came out of me before I'd decided to ask it, that I finally said her name outright — asked her, straight, who he was, the man whose calm I kept buying, forty dollars an hour, four times running. Ruth looked at me for a long moment with that hospitable, trustworthy face, the face that makes strangers hand over their coats and their keys and their whole evening, and said the thing that finally, finally, cracked the story I'd been telling myself open down the middle.

She said, he doesn't even need paying. He seems to enjoy the work. He just doesn't remember doing it, which honestly, between us, makes him easier to manage than anyone else on my payroll.

I asked her his name.

She smiled the exact hospitable smile she'd been wearing since the bottom of the stairwell, and said the thing that customers had been paying to feel, one curtained hour at a time, wasn't a stranger's calm at all. It had never been a stranger's. It was only ever a man's relief at being, for one hour, permitted to stop pretending he didn't already know.

CODA: THE UNLABELED REEL

There was one reel in the back cabinet that didn't have a number on it, the way every other reel on Vine did, filed by date and duration the way a library files anything it wants to be able to find again. Ruth kept that one separately, in a drawer she opened with a key she wore on a chain I hadn't clocked as a key until that night, and she told me, with something that might have been pity, that I could have it for free, because she said, not unkindly, that a man in my condition had earned the right to finally see the whole picture.

I sat in the chair a fifth time. I told myself it was the last time, the way I'd told myself the first four were curiosity, then habit, then research into my own nerves, every gentler word a person keeps in stock for exactly this occasion.

I was in a hallway I recognized before I understood why I recognized it, and the woman in front of me was frightened in the specific way I'd hated myself for recognizing on Vine the very first time, and this time, God help me, this time I understood the geometry of the room before the reel got to the part where it would have shown me, because I already knew where the crack in the floorboard was, and I already knew which way the door stuck, and I already knew, standing in a body that was mine and not mine at the exact same moment for the first time in six weeks of very carefully not asking myself that question, that the woman in the hallway, frightened in the specific way that had been living in my thumb for six weeks like a stain that wouldn't set, was someone I would never be permitted to name, and that I was not, and had never once been, a visitor standing outside the reel looking in.

My hands did the thing my hands had apparently already done once, live, off the tape, on a night I have since reconstructed from a bar tab and a missing six hours and a coat I never found again, and I felt, watching my own hands do it a second time from the inside, the exact vast, cool, complete absence I'd been chasing back to Vine four separate times without ever once letting myself ask what I was actually homesick for.

Ruth wasn't running a supplier. She was running a customer who paid in product instead of cash, a man who came in every few weeks not for the reels but to hand one over, and who left every single time with no memory of the transaction and a gentler story already assembling itself in the drive home about a curious man who'd merely come to watch, and was almost, almost ready to stop.

I built that gentler man out of the same clean absence Halo sells for forty dollars an hour on Vine, because a man can survive almost anything he's done if he gets to be the one visiting the scene instead of the one who made it. I want you to understand

that isn't a metaphor. It's the actual mechanism. It's the whole design of the thing, and I was, this entire time, my own best customer, and my own most reliable source.

REEL FIVE: THE UNREMEMBERED

The parlor on Vine is still open. I know because I still go, though not the way I used to, and not for the reason I used to give myself.

There's a room in the back now — Ruth added it sometime in the last few years, after the story about the man who found out what he was got told enough times in enough basements that it stopped being my story specifically and started being a category, the way any true thing does if enough strangers need somewhere to put it. Eight of us most weeks. Sometimes eleven. People who bought a reel once, or a dozen times, or only ever watched somebody else come down shaking in a curtained booth and knew, the way you know weather changing in your knees, that they'd been standing closer to the center of it than a customer ever gets to stand.

We don't call ourselves anything. We tried Unremembered for a while, because that's the word Ruth used the night she finally told me the truth, and it fit for a while, the way a coat fits until you notice it was cut for somebody else's shoulders. Most of us have simply stopped needing the name.

Here's the first thing you learn in that back room: Halo never needed a monster to keep running. It only ever needed people willing to become one for an hour and then hand the hour to someone kinder to carry the memory of it forward — a stranger, a customer, a self assembled fresh every few weeks out of nothing but relief and a good clean alibi. The supply never dried up, because the supply was never a person Ruth had to go looking for. It was a mechanism, and mechanisms don't quit. They just find the next set of hands willing, however briefly, however sincerely, not to remember whose hands they were.

We read the fifth reel out loud once a month, the one he left behind before whatever happened to him after that finally happened — his own voice, on tape, describing a chair and a curtain and a woman's hospitable, trustworthy face. Most of us can't finish it out loud without stopping. We take turns.

The last line is the only one we say together, plainly, without performing it, because performing it is exactly the kind of thing this whole machine was built to reward.

I was, this entire time, my own best customer, and my own most reliable source.

Some nights, saying it together in that back room, I catch a few of the newer faces doing the math on their own hands, turning them over under the bad light, checking the pads of their thumbs the way you'd check a lottery ticket you were hoping to have lost. Nobody in that room has ever finished the sentence out loud about what they're checking for. I've learned not to ask. I've learned some silences are the only

mercy anybody in that room still has left to give each other, and I've stopped, mostly, calling it mercy at all.